

“I’ve not Shot Film in Six Years”



Dennis Biela
Digital Photographer

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Dennis Biela is carrying two bags and looks like an average traveller. But, if you peek into his bags, you will never call him average—no matter, in what context.

An Apple Powerbook in one bag, and all kinds of photography equipment in the other. Strangely, you won’t find a single film roll. Biela, a U.S. government-certified expert in digital imaging, explains, “I’ve not shot on film in six years.” Coming from a highly-respected professional photographer, whose clients include BMW, the statement is so much more than a matter of fact.

A self-confessed Mac-phile, and founder of the Wayahead Group, Biela recounts how he got started with digital photography when he needed to touch-up a few shots of a BMW racer, taken in the mid 90s. Soon he bought himself a Power-Mac, took a loan to buy a Kodak DCS1 digicam and forgot all about darkrooms. Since then, he has been a beta tester for Kodak and Canon, and also the photographer and lecturer for Apple Computers.

While in India to promote Apple’s QuickTime Virtual Reality technology, he readily admits, “I love (Macromedia) Shockwave” but quickly adds that the plug-in architecture of QuickTime makes it a superior technology. “QuickTime is like a bucket, you can put anything in it.”

And that’s exactly what he has done with QuickTime’s VR extension. He is currently working on a major project with The National Air and Space Museum in Washington, DC. He demos a few VR media files on his notebook—all are inside shots of classic airplanes, including the famous Wright flyer. His plan is to rent out handheld computers to museum visitors, who can view the insides of these airplanes on a palmtop, while touring the museum.

Currently, the car industry is the biggest user of QuickTime VR. Biela says Macs are his choice for digital imaging because of the user-friendly interface. When questioned about consumer-end digital cameras, Biela cites that digicams are making their presence felt—Kodak is 40 per cent down in its film-roll business.

Biela has some advice for digital photography newbies—“the most expensive camera is not necessarily the best for you; each camera is for made for a different purpose.” His favourite example is that, “You need a really fast camera for clicking kids, who hardly ever pose for pics as compared to mountains, which never move.” He also urges beginners to “shoot in raw mode, if your camera supports it.” For archiving purposes, he suggested two CD-R backups and InMedia software for cataloging.

More importantly, he stresses on the fact that there are no better or worse photographers; just photographers with different styles. Leveraging technology can really add to a photographer’s style. And this is what Biela does best. An anecdote he detailed will suffice to prove the point:

A friend was getting married and could not afford to hire Biela in a professional capacity. So, he requested Biela to do the job for free. Biela quickly agreed. At the wedding, he clicked away with his digital camera and at the reception he started waving his wand. He dumped all the photos from the camera to his PowerBook, which was hooked onto a video projector. He then used iTunes (bundled with Mac OS X) and created a slideshow. The wedding guests, were thrilled and wanted to buy prints of the pictures. Customer’s credit cards were charged—the pictures will be delivered via an online photo-finishing firm. He also burnt DVDs of the slideshow on his laptop. The DVDs sold at \$39.95 a pop, and by the end of the day Biela had made a cool \$3,200 from a free wedding.

As we’re winding up Biela says, “You have to be more savvy on the computer.” He also says to watch out for online photo-finishing firms, some of which will make a lot of money and change the way we photograph our loved ones.

Biela is happy with the way technology has changed his world, “It’s a good thing,” he says, adding, “There’s lots of stuff to keep track of and learn, and I can decide what I need or don’t.” In the last few years, Biela confesses, he decided to use film just once—at his sister’s birthday party. ■

As told to Vivek Shankar